

Palm Island
COMMUNITY COMPANY

2023 - 2024

ANNUAL REPORT

Message from the CEO

In 2018/19 I wrote, "Now that our first decade is behind us, watch this space for what we will achieve in our second." With PICC more than halfway through our second decade now, our achievements are growing almost by the day.

The pace at which PICC has been evolving is nothing short of remarkable. Our expanded investment in services has significantly strengthened and enhanced them, making them more robust and effective than ever before.

We now employ three times the number of people compared to ten years ago and our turnover has quadrupled. This substantial growth is directly benefiting Palm Islanders, either through the services we provide or the jobs we offer.

One of the changes I am most excited about is the delegated authority, which represents a significant and positive shift for children in care on Palm Island. At last, the community will decide the care arrangements for children who cannot stay at home.

The number of staff and trainees we employ has increased by a third since last year, with nearly two hundred people now working for PICC. Impressively, three-quarters of our workforce are Palm Islanders.

Everything we do is for, with, and because of the people of this beautiful community.

Rachel Atkinson

Chief Executive Officer

Message from the Chair

In my fifth year as Chair of the Board, my commitment to ensuring that PICC remains the exemplary service provider that Palm Island deserves has only grown stronger.

PICC plays a crucial role in our community, offering essential services that impact the lives of many. I am deeply conscious of the responsibility I hold to the people of Palm Island, ensuring that our company is not only well-managed and sustainable but also progressing in the right direction.

The positive changes we strive for are becoming evident within the community. This is particularly noticeable among our young people, who are beginning to feel a sense of optimism about the future of Palm Island.

I am immensely grateful for the unwavering support of my fellow Board members. Together, we are steering PICC towards a brighter future for Palm Island.

Luella Bligh

Chair, Board of Directors

Executive Summary

The 2023-24 fiscal year represents a transformative period for the Palm Island Community Company. With 197 dedicated staff members delivering 16+ integrated services, we continue to strengthen our community-controlled approach to holistic wellbeing and self-determination.

This year saw the historic implementation of Delegated Authority under the Child Protection Act – a decades-long goal achieved. Our community now decides care arrangements for children who cannot stay at home, marking a profound shift toward true self-determination.

Our health service delivered 17,488 episodes of care to 2,283 clients. Safe Haven supported 1,187 children. The Family Care Service provided 6,698 placement nights. These numbers represent real families, real healing, real change.

Staff numbers grew 30% to 197, with over 70% being Palm Islanders – extraordinarily high for remote communities. This is our strength: local people serving local families with deep cultural understanding.

Revenue reached \$23.4 million, quadrupling over the past decade. Every dollar invested returns multiple times over in community benefit, employment, and opportunity.

Year at a Glance

197

Total Staff
Members

\$23.4M

Total Revenue

16

Integrated
Services

2,283

Health Clients

17,488

Episodes of
Care

1,187

Children
Supported

These figures represent a 30% growth in staff numbers from 2023, with turnover quadrupling over the past decade. Over 70% of staff are Palm Islanders, and over 80% identify as Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander.

Key Highlights

Delegated Authority

Historic achievement of community control over child protection decisions. \$107.8M funding over 4 years.

30% Workforce Growth

Staff increased from 151 to 197, with over 70% being Palm Islanders.

First 1,000 Days Program

New program ensuring Indigenous families get quicker access to care during critical early childhood.

Digital Service Centre

Telstra partnership creating 21 quality jobs with capacity for 30, supporting 50 languages.

Health Service Expansion

17,488 episodes of care delivered to 2,283 clients through culturally appropriate services.

Family Services Strengthened

Safe Haven supported 1,187 children; Family Care provided 6,698 placement nights.

Corporate Governance

PICC is governed by a Board of Directors elected by community members. As an Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community-controlled organization, only Palm Islanders can be members, ensuring true community ownership and accountability.

Members of the Board

Name	Position
Luella Bligh	Chair
Rhonda Phillips	Director
Allan Palm Island	Director
Matthew Lindsay	Company Secretary
Harriet Hulthen	Director
Raymond W. Palmer Snr	Director
Cassie Lang	Director

Report Card: Staff Numbers

	30 June 2024	30 June 2023	30 June 2022
No. of staff members	197	151	152

Bwgcorman Way: Delegated Authority

A major change to caring arrangements for vulnerable children is at last coming to Palm Island: delegated authority.

The implementation of Delegated Authority under Sections 148BA and 148BB(3) of the Child Protection Act 1999 represents a historic milestone for Palm Island.

PICC has chosen to name this approach Bwgcorman Way: Empowered and Resilient. "Bwgcorman" meaning "many tribes, one people".

The vision is that all Manbarra and Bwgcorman children are safe and cared for by family, nurtured by strong and enduring connections to their community, culture and Country. Palm Island mob leading and creating change for Palm Island children, young people and families.

This authority, backed by \$107.8 million in funding over four years, puts decision-making power where it belongs: with the people who know our children, our families, and our culture best.

”

When we make decisions about our children, they need to be made by people who understand our families, our history, our culture.

— Community Elder, Palm Island

Primary Health Services

(Bwgcolman Healing Service)

The Bwgcolman Healing Service delivered comprehensive primary healthcare to 2,283 clients through 17,488 episodes of care. Our culturally appropriate approach combines Western medicine with traditional healing practices.

In early 2024, the Bwgcolman Healing Service passed the Quality Practice Accreditation assessment by the Royal Australian College of General Practitioners. The assessors made special mention of the outstanding cleanliness, high documentation standards, and excellent professional standards.

Metric	2023/24	2022/23	2021/22
Total Clients	2,283	2,050	1,965
Episodes of Care	17,488	18,021	18,510
Health Checks (715)	779	610	873
Child Health Checks	128	345	167
GP Management Plans	293	411	124

Community Services

Our community services span the full spectrum of support, from early intervention to crisis response. The Children and Family Centre serves as a hub for family support, with programs tailored to Palm Island's large youth population (32% aged 14 or under).

Safe Haven supported 1,187 children, providing a safe space during family crisis. The Safe House delivered 1,439 placement nights. Family Care Service provided 6,698 placement nights, keeping children connected to family and community.

Service	2023/24	2022/23	2021/22
Family Care - Placement Nights	6,698	5,656	5,390
Safe House - Placement Nights	1,439	1,069	1,387
Safe Haven - Children Supported	1,187	950	934
Diversionary Services Users	500+	1,446	1,167

Economic Development

Economic self-sufficiency is central to community empowerment. Our social enterprises employ 44 staff, while the Telstra Digital Service Centre has created 21 high-quality jobs.

The Digital Service Centre, developed in partnership with Telstra, Advance Queensland, and the Deadly Innovation Strategy, demonstrates what's possible when investment meets community capability. Staff complete 12 weeks of TAFE training, 5 weeks of Telstra-specific training, and earn a Certificate III in Business.

Currently supporting customers across 50 languages, the centre has capacity for 30 staff – a target we're working toward as we continue recruitment and training.

”

Quality jobs that don't require leaving Country – that's the future we're building.

— Rachel Atkinson, CEO

Our People

PICC's workforce grew 30% to 197 staff – tripling over the past decade. More remarkably, over 70% are Palm Islanders, and over 80% identify as Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander.

This level of local employment is extraordinarily high for remote communities. It means families can stay together, income stays in the community, and our services are delivered by people with deep cultural understanding.

We invest heavily in training and professional development, creating clear career pathways from entry-level positions to leadership roles.



Summary Financial Report

30 June 2024

Balance Sheet

	2024	2023
Current Assets	\$8,156,480	\$5,428,897
Non Current Assets	\$2,702,284	\$1,633,389
TOTAL Assets	\$10,858,764	\$7,062,286
Current Liabilities	\$5,969,264	\$3,025,785
Non Current Liabilities	\$1,351,259	\$220,537
TOTAL Liabilities	\$7,320,523	\$3,246,322
NET ASSETS	\$3,538,241	\$3,815,964

Income and Expenditure

	2024	2023
INCOME	\$23,400,335	\$20,103,686
Total Labour Costs (60%)	\$14,282,962	\$11,477,036
Administration (21%)	\$5,000,820	\$4,133,848
Travel & Training (8%)	\$1,778,367	\$1,611,707
Client Costs (5%)	\$1,156,713	\$1,094,877
Property & Energy (4%)	\$1,058,084	\$710,794
Motor Vehicle (2%)	\$401,112	\$360,093
TOTAL Expenditure	\$23,678,058	\$19,388,354

Our 16 Services

- Bwgcolman Healing Service
- Community Justice Group
- Digital Service Centre
- Diversionary Service
- Early Childhood Services (CFC)
- Family Care Service
- Family Participation Program
- Family Wellbeing Centre
- NDIS Service
- Safe Haven
- Safe House
- Social and Emotional Wellbeing Service
- Specialist Domestic and Family Violence Service
- Women's Healing Service
- Women's Service
- Youth Service

Our Partners

PICC acknowledges our partners: Queensland Government, NIAA, Queensland Health, North Queensland Primary Health Network, Telstra, James Cook University, TAFE Queensland, Palm Island Aboriginal Shire Council, and many more who make our work possible.

Looking Forward

As we enter 2024-25, PICC is positioned for continued growth and impact.

Expanding the First 1,000 Days program to ensure every child gets the best possible start in life. This evidence-based approach to early childhood development will have generational impact.

Strengthening our Delegated Authority implementation through the Bwgcolman Way framework. Community-led decision making for child welfare is now a reality – our task is to make it work brilliantly.

Growing the Digital Service Centre to its full 30-person capacity. This Telstra partnership represents the future of remote employment – quality jobs that don't require leaving Country.

Deepening cultural connection across all programs. Language revitalization, cultural healing, and connection to Country remain at the heart of everything we do.

Building workforce capability through training, mentorship, and clear career pathways. Our people are our greatest asset.

The road ahead is one we walk together – community members, staff, board, and partners united in service of Palm Island's future.

Acknowledgments

Palm Island Community Company acknowledges the Manbarra people as the Traditional Owners of Great Palm Island and the surrounding waters. We pay our respects to Elders past, present, and emerging.

We honor the 42 language groups whose descendants now call Palm Island home – the Bwgcolman, "many tribes" brought together. We acknowledge the profound impact of historical policies, including the Hull River relocation and the Stolen Generations.

PICC thanks our funding partners: Queensland Government, NIAA, Queensland Health, and Northern Queensland Primary Health Network. We thank Telstra for their vision in establishing the Digital Service Centre.

Most importantly, we thank the Palm Island community – the families who trust us with their care, the Elders who guide us, the staff who serve tirelessly, and the young people who inspire us with their potential.

This report is dedicated to all who have contributed to making Palm Island a safer, stronger, and more prosperous place to live.

”

Our Community, Our Future, Our Way

— Palm Island Community Company